

6/ Considering Interdisciplinarity and Diversity

We are clearly without any kind of mystery about it: criteria other than excellence are being used.

Political scientist

Although the criteria of interdisciplinarity and diversity are used to distinguish one proposal from another, they do not speak to quality per se. Instead, they concern characteristics of proposals and applicants that may push a very good but not perfect project or candidate over the proverbial bar. As such, diversity in particular can act as an additive, rather than as an alternative, standard of evaluation.

The discussion focuses first on the distinct challenges raised by the evaluation of interdisciplinary proposals and explores how panelists define “good interdisciplinarity” given the general lack of consensus in this area. That the necessary types of expertise are rarely combined within a single person partly accounts for the difficulties of evaluating interdisciplinary research. Falling back on disciplinary standards is the path of least resistance.

We will see that in the world of funding panels, as in the world of American higher education, diversity takes many forms and comes in many hues. Yet while public debates center mainly on the place of racial and gender diversity in higher education, panelists assign the most weight to institutional and disciplinary diversity. Various types of diversity are valued as an intrinsic good that contributes to the overall quality of the research environment. Concerns for representation and efficacy (being truthful to the organizational mission) are factored into arguments in favor of diversity, but diversity is also valued as a component of excellence and as a means of redressing past injustices, leveling the playing field, and shaping the academic pipeline.

The five competitions under consideration are multidisciplinary in the sense that they aim to fund proposals emanating from a range of disciplines and their panel members are drawn from various disciplines (see Chapter 2). But these competitions all fund, in varying proportions, both disciplinary and interdisciplinary proposals. Only three of the sponsors explicitly encourage interdisciplinary scholarship.¹ As for diversity, while some competitions, such as that of the American Council for Learned Societies, specify that “minorities and other groups are encouraged to apply,” others do not mention diversity criteria in their guidelines to panelists or applicants. Such considerations have become part of the taken-for-granted standards used for evaluation across a range of settings in American higher education; and most of the funding organizations I studied promote diversity as part of their broader organizational mandate. Not surprisingly, then, when reporting arguments made in favor and against proposals, the interviewees routinely refer to the influence of various kinds of diversity.

Critics of affirmative action believe that factoring in diversity poses challenges related to fairness. As explained by the political theorist Michael Walzer in his classic *Spheres of Justice*, justice is not one idea but several, because there is no single criterion by which justice

should be assessed.² Principles of justice such as merit, need, and distributive fairness are not all of the same order and they often clash with one another. The French sociologists Luc Boltanski and Laurent Thévenot, however, suggest that “compromise” can often be reached between competing principles of legitimation.³ How panelists balance excellence and diversity is a case in point, as we will see.

Tensions between excellence and diversity, and meritocracy and democracy, remain at the center of debates about peer review. The spatial dispersion of the American higher education system over a very large territory, its institutional diversity (covering public and private universities, as well as research universities, small liberal arts colleges, and community colleges), and the sociodemographic diversity of administrators, faculty, and students all keep these tensions alive. Against such a diverse landscape, winners should be chosen from a variety of groups and regions, and panelists should be somewhat representative of the broader population. For instance, winners cannot all come from a few select institutions in the Northeast—this would undermine the legitimacy of peer review as a meritocratic and democratic system. Such a result would likely be viewed as an organizational failure and/or as the outcome of elitism (opportunity hoarding) or poor procedures. The democratic impulse attenuates the steep institutional hierarchies that characterize American higher education, but it does not impede an unconditional celebration of excellence and meritocracy, which is viewed elsewhere as the expression of a certain social Darwinism.⁴

Rewards and Challenges of Interdisciplinary Evaluation

Interdisciplinarity has many manifestations, including the degree to which disciplinary boundaries are permeable and the extent to which disciplines are conceptually integrated.⁵ More specifically, interdisciplinarity typically involves (1) developing conceptual links

by using a perspective in one discipline to modify a perspective in another discipline, (2) using research techniques developed in one discipline to elaborate a theoretical model in another, (3) developing a new theoretical framework that may reconceptualize research in two or more separate domains as it attempts to integrate them, and (4) modifying a theoretical framework characteristic of one domain and then applying it to another.⁶

Interdisciplinarity has been a priority in the funding world for several years. It is favored by the leaders in federal funding (the National Institutes of Health and the National Science Foundation), by universities eager to stake out new territory that will raise their profile, and by a number of private foundations.⁷ Thus the funding competitions I studied are not exceptional in promoting interdisciplinarity. Program officers take organizational guidelines seriously; in putting together funding panels, they factor in potential members' interdisciplinary orientation. Consequently, during interviews, many panelists were vocal in their appreciation for interdisciplinary research. An English professor's comments capture this enthusiasm: "The more subjects you canvas, the more likely you are to approach your topic fairly . . . Putting things together that are not usually put together is a good thing to do, an [innovation] that might produce useful knowledge." In addition to its role in producing "useful knowledge," interdisciplinarity is valued because it improves one's "ability to speak to different sets of people," thus broadening a project's intellectual reach. Yet as we will see, panelists also acknowledge that "true" or "good" interdisciplinarity is often elusive.

Doing It Well

After briefly establishing his identity as an interdisciplinary scholar ("I read things in anthropology, sociology, probably less in political science and literature"), a historian notes that interdisciplinarity "is a

challenging thing to do effectively,” and concedes that “there are valid criticisms about the way historians have sometimes adopted tools and ideas from other fields.” Indeed, some critics dismiss interdisciplinary research as a fad, and as a form of scholarship that is not easily amenable to evaluation.⁸ Others have argued that the very notion of “peer review” cannot be validly applied to interdisciplinary research.⁹ It is in this context that social scientists have begun thinking systematically about the challenges of evaluating interdisciplinarity—an underexplored topic.¹⁰ They have identified some criteria specific to the assessment of interdisciplinarity (for example, consistency with previous research, balance between interdisciplinary perspectives, and potential effectiveness).¹¹ There is also some agreement on the potential pitfalls of interdisciplinary scholarship. The panelists speak to both aspects, describing some of the positive as well as negative attributes of interdisciplinary work (and those who undertake it).

The best interdisciplinary proposals successfully combine breadth, parsimony, and soundness. Here is how a geographer goes about identifying applicants who meet these stringent standards:

To be an artful and talented researcher, [what] one has to do is actually master several fields . . . You have to be able to talk the talk of several disciplines, but to be able to see where cutting edges are and take certain gambles in terms of advancing an idea . . . I take a risk on [proposals that have] interesting ideas, even if they’re bumping into different fields. I look very carefully at the training [of the applicant], who they’re working with, the scholarship of the person they have worked with, to assess whether I think this person is actually capable of raising some big questions.

A historian focuses on the dialogic character of successful interdisciplinary proposals.¹² “To hit a basic threshold of significance,” he explains, the proposal must speak to different disciplines simulta-

neously: “If you can reach people outside your field, you’re interdisciplinary . . . A proposal that is able to speak across disciplinary idioms to a majority of people on the panel is going to be a suitable proposal.” The best interdisciplinary proposals are also integrative, that is, they bring together ideas and approaches from different disciplines.¹³ Thus, unsurprisingly, among the pitfalls and drawbacks that respondents identify, a primary concern is overreaching or over-ambitiousness. As an English professor points out, “Projects that have a lot of ambition to reach beyond the person’s initial field; they’re risky. The person might not be able to do what they want to do. Over-ambitiousness was what was both attractive and fatal for some of the projects.” A historian couples superficiality with overreach, maintaining that “if you are interdisciplinary, the burden is upon you, the candidate, to be aware of that discipline and not do shoddy work.” This same panelist offers the following telling comparison of two applicants from literary studies, each of whom proposed to use a historical approach:

She did what he failed to do. She’s not an historian, but she didn’t get the history wrong, and she grounded [the proposal] correctly in context. And I could see how the work would contribute to this sort of interdisciplinary approach where she’s trying to look at this literature historically within that context. The few literature proposals that I’ve gotten have just been very bad for the very reasons that I’m describing—they’re all over the map. They have no real grounding in context. They bandy theory that isn’t well integrated. I . . . ranked them quite harshly.

Flashiness, too, is often associated with overreach. Another historian, contrasting flashy and real interdisciplinarity, says of flashiness:

There is a . . . way of doing things in which you use your knowledge of the other things, the things outside your discipline, more

as a rhetorical strategy than as something in which you really steep yourself in. It's always a danger in interdisciplinary work.

An English professor offers a similar criticism when she describes as “fast and loose” an interdisciplinary project concerning capitalism and the economic and political power of native Americans: “A fast and loose project would be throwing around some interdisciplinary vocabulary . . . It would pull in Gayatri Spivak and Benedict Anderson and throw them into some kind [of] theoretical soup, maybe just be tagging phrases and not really applying their theories in any kind of deep way.” Although many have clear ideas about what makes for bad interdisciplinary research, the greatest difficulties it poses concern how to assess it fairly and with consensus.

Evaluating It Well

The standards used to evaluate interdisciplinary research are not a simple combination of the standards of single disciplines. They are a hybrid, and an emergent hybrid at that—one that has developed through practice and deliberation. Because the criteria have these emergent qualities, some panelists believe that interdisciplinary panels are more open-minded than regular, single-discipline panels, that there is a greater willingness to “listen to other people’s criteria and sort of question your own . . . to change their minds or to reconsider.” Others believe that such panels are more conservative than their disciplinary counterparts.¹⁴ This conservative bias may be influenced by the members’ age; panelists tend to be older than the average applicants to most competitions. Older scholars have been less socialized to appreciate interdisciplinary work. Mentioning a controversial tenure case at her elite institution, an English scholar remarks that “especially older colleagues are very unwilling even to approach judging [this scholar’s] work. They just want to say, ‘We

shouldn't have this kind of work because we can't judge it. We can't tell whether it's good or bad.' And that seems to me a terrible reason to fire someone." As in tenure decisions, the challenge of fairly evaluating interdisciplinary proposals is not helped by the fact that typically no panelist has mastered all the knowledge needed to assess competently all of their aspects.¹⁵ Sometimes no consensus emerges about whose disciplinary sovereignty should be deferred to, which means that evaluating interdisciplinary research can be an especially risky venture.

Interdisciplinarity often brings about a broadening and multiplication of evaluation criteria, which makes both individual judgment and group agreement much more difficult. The same English professor quoted earlier notes that in her field, the traditional criteria used with regard to close reading is whether the author can perform a "subtle, accurate reading" of a sonnet, for instance. In the case of interdisciplinary work, the criteria become whether the argument is "plausible, persuasive, how is evidence used." And although the use of evidence is a constant, it is often difficult or impossible for panelists to know whether an applicant is proposing to use the most appropriate evidence available. Only those extremely familiar with the specific case are in a position to evaluate this aspect—and even across academia in general, the number of such competent judges is likely to be very small. This same English professor, whose scholarship is well known and highly regarded, illustrates the dilemma by describing her own experience undertaking an interdisciplinary research project:

You take your theoretical frame from some existing source. If you're writing about sexuality, you would follow the rules laid down by Foucault, so that it would be possible to judge whether someone was pursuing a Foucaultian reading in a proper way. [However], I felt that I certainly knew more about these journalis-

tic accounts [I was studying] than anybody else did, and that meant that nobody really ever could say that I was wrong, and that made me worried . . . They would inevitably be impressed by the fancy footwork that I performed with these sources, but it would be difficult for someone to say that I had read them wrong.

As this quote suggests, the lack of canonized agreement about how to evaluate interdisciplinarity gives researchers more leeway concerning how to go about their work, but it also creates greater uncertainty about how to establish the resulting project's quality. A historian emphasizes the importance of using "other fields' toolkits" in a disciplined way. This approach he contrasts with "the kind of interdisciplinarity that Stanley Fish once complained about, which is basically the person who makes up his own standards and therefore is bound by no one. I am interested in consciously trying to sort of broker useful relations between disciplinary toolkits."

Combining traditional standards of disciplinary excellence with interdisciplinarity presents a potential for double jeopardy. This is because expert and generalist criteria (what one respondent defines as "virtuosity and significance") have to be met at the same time. Because interdisciplinary research is a hybrid form, the usual criteria of evaluation—originality and significance, for instance—may end up being weighted differently. A historian of China says it is important to have

the endorsement of specialists who feel that . . . this [is] going to satisfy needs in your particular discipline. I mean only after we got a "yes" to that would I want to go on. Now we apply the second tier of criteria, which is, "Is it going to do anything for anybody else?" The first thing in the sequence . . . certifies people as competent in their, as it were, local expertises. But to me, that's not the ultimate criteria. The ultimate criterion is, is it going to do anything for the rest of us.

Not surprisingly, given the emergent quality of the standards of evaluation for interdisciplinary genres, panelists readily fall back on existing disciplinary standards to determine what should and should not be funded. This may mean that at the end of the day, interdisciplinary scholarship is evaluated through several disciplinary lenses. That is the conclusion my colleagues and I reached in our study of cognitive contextualization and the production of fair judgments within interdisciplinary panels.¹⁶ Of course, more research is needed in this area, particularly concerning the creation and evaluation of shared interdisciplinary cognitive platforms.¹⁷ We also need to understand better the weak institutionalization of interdisciplinary criteria of evaluation in the face of considerable available funding, governmental mandates for interdisciplinary research, and industry's appreciation of it. Is ambiguity inherent to the genre?

While "good" interdisciplinary evaluation calls for a very distinct, if rare, combination of expertise, "good" diversity evaluation raises questions of a different order. These have to do with fundamental principles—how to reconcile evaluation based on merit, on the one hand, and evaluation based on needs and distributive justice, on the other.

Including Diversity Criteria

Many studies demonstrate the relatively few women and minority faculty members in the most prestigious levels of academia—in particular, tenured positions at research universities that have high levels of influence and productivity.¹⁸ Although faculty diversity is increasing, unequal access to higher education continues to affect the pipeline.¹⁹ It is against this background that diversity considerations affect all forms of selection in American higher education, ranging from law school admissions and department tenure decisions, to the awarding of fellowships.

Just as with interdisciplinarity, some of the funding agencies in-

cluded in this study explicitly require that panelists do not discriminate. For instance, the website for the American Council for Learned Societies asserts:

In the administration and awarding of its fellowships and grants, the ACLS does not discriminate on the basis of race, color, sex, sexual orientation, national origin, age, religion, disability, marital/family status, or political affiliation. Applications are particularly invited from women and members of minority groups. Younger scholars and independent scholars who do not hold academic appointments are also encouraged to apply.²⁰

Other funding organizations are less specific. For instance, the website of the Woodrow Wilson National Fellowship Foundation, sponsor of the Women's Studies competition, simply states, "Since its earliest days, the Woodrow Wilson Foundation has broken barriers and opened doors for students whose access to the best educational opportunities had been limited. Woodrow Wilson continues to meet the nation's needs to cultivate young leaders who truly represent all Americans."²¹ Two of the funding agencies do not mention diversity. Nevertheless, it is reasonable to expect that all panelists take it into consideration when making awards; diversity's relevance to academic evaluation is widely acknowledged in settings where panel members typically perform their day-to-day work as evaluators of colleagues and students. While they are generally asked only not to discriminate, diversity is often actively factored into decision making.

Promoting Many Diversities: Why and How

Panelists appear to favor an expansive definition of diversity that does not privilege race or gender, and that aims to promote diversity within academia because it is perceived as an intrinsic good, leading

Table 6.1 Percent of panelists per disciplinary cluster who mention diversity as a criterion

<i>Types of diversity</i>	<i>Humanities</i> (<i>N</i> = 22)	<i>History</i> (<i>N</i> = 20)	<i>Social sciences</i> (<i>N</i> = 29)	<i>Total</i> (<i>N</i> = 71)
Institutional	9 (41%)	8 (40%)	8 (28%)	25 (35%)
Disciplinary	7 (32%)	9 (45%)	8 (28%)	24 (34%)
Topics	6 (27%)	9 (45%)	5 (17%)	20 (28%)
Gender	0 (0%)	5 (25%)	6 (21%)	11 (15%)
Ethno-racial	4 (18%)	3 (15%)	3 (10%)	10 (14%)
Geographic	1 (5%)	0 (0%)	0 (0%)	1 (1%)
Total	27 (1.2*)	34 (1.7**)	30 (1.03**)	91**

Note: A “mention” occurs when a criterion is used during the interview.

* This number represents the ratio of mention per panelist. While some respondents mentioned each type of diversity more than once, their concern is registered only once for each diversity type.

**Some panelists mentioned two types of diversity. Thus, the total number of mentions is greater than the total number of panelists.

to a richer academic experience for all and to a broader production of talent for society as a whole.²² Panelists do consider the racial and gender diversity of the awardees, but they also weigh their geographical location, the types of institutions where they teach (public/private, elite/nonelite, colleges/research universities), and the range of disciplines they hail from. Which kind of diversity is privileged from case to case is an object of negotiation among panel members. As shown in Table 6.1, around 34 percent of the interviewees mention institutional diversity and disciplinary diversity as criteria of evaluation, compared to only about 15 percent who mention ethno-racial or gender diversity. Diversity in topics is also a popular criterion. Only one respondent mentions geographic diversity.

Historians are most concerned with diversity in topics and disciplinary diversity (this may reflect noblesse oblige, given that historians reap the lion’s share of the awards and submit a very large number of proposals). Social scientists are the least concerned with these two dimensions. Surprisingly, the humanists do not mention gender diversity, while, as the table shows, this is a relatively strong factor

among historians and social scientists. Mentions of ethno-racial diversity are roughly equal across disciplinary clusters. Overall, the concern for diversity is strongest among historians (with a ratio of 1.7 mentions per respondent in this cluster, compared to 1.2 among humanists, and 1.03 among social scientists). It should be mentioned that while panelists have access to information concerning applicants' disciplinary affiliation, gender, institutional affiliation (and its geographic location), and research topic, they often have to guess ethno-racial identity based on applicants' past awards (for example, having received minority fellowships) and affiliations (such as membership in the Association of Black Sociologists).

Given the many forms of diversity and the relatively low salience of ethno-racial diversity as compared to disciplinary and institutional diversity, it is not surprising that when asked how much importance should be attached to diversity as a criterion of selection, an African-American scholar responds by referring to projects emanating from private and public universities as well as to competitions that target "younger scholars or ethnic minorities." He explicitly views policies aiming to promote racial diversity as exemplifying the promotion of a much broader principle of diversity. Some respondents go even further. A history professor says, "I do believe in having a mix, as much of a mix as possible, as much diversity of whatever kind. And that includes diversity of background or training or interest or maybe even age or personality." Framing the funding of women and people of color as the extension of a broader principle minimizes what could be perceived as an antinomy between promoting excellence and fairness. Since the 1980s, a similar trend has developed in other fields, such as organizational management, partly in response to federal cutbacks in affirmative action and equal opportunity regulations.²³

Pro-diversity arguments are made by evoking not only the intrinsic value of diversity, but also the need to level the playing field and overcome biases (rationales that are often combined) in order to

bring out the best work. “It’s important for foundations such as these to encourage the production of as wide a range of knowledge as possible,” one English scholar asserts, explaining that this process “helps us check some of the biases that we as evaluators may bring in. And I think it also allows us to ‘level the playing field.’ That’s a metaphor that gets used often in terms of racial or class diversity, which I totally think is important.” An African-American panelist also defends factoring in diversity by appealing to fairness in light of this uneven playing field. As he notes, “You’ve got people applying who teach at institutions where they have much heavier teaching loads and haven’t had opportunities to publish as much. It is often the case that their proposals may not look as slick and polished—I should say ‘polished,’ I shouldn’t say ‘slick.’ They may not have been able to maintain connections to leaders in the field whose names carry some kind of weight or who may have some kind of facility with letters of recommendation.”

Still other panel members are concerned with the role that fellowships play in shaping the academic pipeline and in determining what the professoriate will look like in the next decades. According to a self-identified liberal historian:

Since [the competition] is a gateway to the academy, I’m interested in seeing the academy have more than just white, upper-middle-class, careerist professionals [who] essentially come at this with a kind of dogged, mandarin-like desire to reproduce themselves in the academy . . . It’s nice to see somebody [who] did different work, older candidates and young candidates . . . if at the end of the day you’ve essentially given a license to a group of people [to] fill out the academy with very different personalit[ies] and different backgrounds, that’s . . . a massive plus.

As Lani Guinier and Susan Sturm point out, critics of affirmative action today find it easy to pit meritocracy against diversity, arguing

that some “get in by merit,” while others do so “by quota.”²⁴ The case of peer review suggests another perspective, one where considerations of quality and diversity are combined to identify potential awardees. Awards are made to applicants who shine in both dimensions, even if in varying proportions; thus, I argue that merit and diversity often act as complementary criteria, rather than as alternative standards of evaluation. Consider how the promotion of diversity is typically accomplished in funding decisions. Arguments about diversity are rarely salient when the first awards are made—the awards around which strong consensus emerges rapidly. Such arguments are more likely to be advanced when the “maybe” proposals are discussed. In these cases, diversity, in its various forms, may act as a tie-breaker between two somewhat faulty—but each differently faulty and thus not easily commensurable—proposals, and thereby help “move things along.” An evaluator who describes the self-monitoring process in which her panel was engaged gives an example. After members noted that they seemed to be funding a disproportionately large number of proposals by historians, the panel took corrective action: “Certain projects were included in our top list by taking into consideration field diversity as well as other kinds of [criteria, such as] institutional range, geographical range, all of which I think are very important categories.” As an African-American English professor summarizes the situation: “Some [winners] are there because of questions having to do with field diversity and a diversity of kind of institutions, because [there is] less of a consensus about the qualities of the proposal. In other cases, there’s more of a consensus that the project is suitable.”

Note that those who benefit from diversity considerations may have had to overcome additional hurdles and stigmas based on their institutional affiliation, class, race, or nativity to join the pool of contestants. That these applicants’ trajectory may have been steeper suggests perhaps their greater determination and potential to succeed compared to applicants from more privileged backgrounds.

Panelists are aware that they apply different standards as the group's deliberations progress beyond the few proposals for which a consensus is reached rather quickly. An English scholar states:

We all talked about weaknesses in [the last six] in ways we hadn't talked about [the others] . . . This is one where the topic may have been the criterion that made the difference, and this speaks to the affirmative action business. I'm comfortable with saying, "The top six are decided on this academic excellence, and then there are other factors that have more weight with the others" . . . Taking the other criteria into account [is important] . . . We're talking about relevance of study, how important a study is to a particular field, or many fields at this particular point in time, how much it's needed.

Thus consistency in the use of rules competes with other considerations as the panelists assess and reassess what constitutes a fair process for the group of proposals as a whole.

"Excellence versus Diversity"

Whether it is appropriate to "factor in" diversity criteria remains a contentious question among many academics, because many are unaware that most decisions are de facto based on a combination of excellence and diversity considerations. Purists argue that only excellence should be considered in the distribution of awards.²⁵ An economist, for instance, is skeptical of panels' ability to accommodate diversity considerations ("it's only under a very unlikely roll of the dice that you would get talent"). He argues that

Academia is intrinsically an elitist enterprise. We don't let everybody into college in this country; we don't let everybody into grad school; we don't give everybody a tenure track job; we don't ten-

ure everybody. And that's a good thing . . . It's kind of like a popular feel-good urge to say, "Let's root for the underdog and hope they win." I think you should fund underdogs if they've got a good proposal.

Anticipating such objections, "progressive" panelists introduce nuances in the collective conversation around these issues. For instance, an English professor argues that producing diverse knowledge fosters excellence and should not be equated with a lowering of standards. Others take a strong stance in favor of combining types of criteria. Thus a political scientist explains, "Well, it's healthy when there are competing criteria put forward vigorously in dialogue with one another. And I think it's healthy to temper your own criteria with consideration of alternative criteria. I think where we get into trouble is where one set of criteria, whether it's excellence or diversity or what have you, are used to the exclusion of all other criteria." Still others seem to want to promote diversity, but within limits, and on a case-by-case basis, as this English professor suggests:

We shouldn't run a place on some abstract idea, or a contextualist idea of academic excellence, because that would privilege one class of people and it wouldn't do anything for diversity. How far one strays from academic excellence to meet the other goals, you probably have to do that pragmatically, case by case, moment by moment. But I think it should be done.

In promoting greater racial and gender diversity among awardees, some panelists purposefully aim to break down the opposition between "standards of excellence" and "diversity standards." A prominent feminist who has served for many years on panels at the National Endowment for the Humanities and the American Association of University Women recalls promoting women academics and wo-

men's studies proposals at a time when these organizations were not inclined to fund them. She explains that she "would not argue for them as women's studies projects, but as being excellent," stating that over time general standards of excellence and standards pertaining to feminist scholarship have converged, so that now they are nearly indistinguishable. Speaking of the Woodrow Wilson Women's Studies competition, she says:

To me, to win one of these [fellowships], you can't have one without the other . . . Women's studies scholars . . . really do have to master more. Because you could be very good, say, in seventeenth-century literature, and not pay any attention to women . . . But to win in this competition, you would have to not only master that field, but also master the feminist theory that speaks to that field. And I think they're absolutely crucial, they've got to have both.

Speaking of her own past, she recalls, "I had to be excellent in the standard fields and then be excellent in women's studies . . . Some of the people who had done more conventional work [in the past] chalked it up to, 'Oh, well, she does feminist stuff and that's really hot.'" That this panelist and others have experienced strong tensions between (not to mention discrimination over) being appreciated for high-quality scholarship and doing innovative work that contributes to the institutionalization of a new field speaks to the pervasive and far-reaching drama of diversity in academic evaluation.

Perspectives on Diversity: Panelists of Color

I conducted nine interviews with nonwhite panelists—seven African-American and two Asian evaluators. As in the larger group of respondents, here too I found significant variation in the approach to diversity as a criterion of selection. At one end of the spectrum, one

panelist explicitly aims to ensure that diversity in all its manifestations is represented among the winners: "My agenda was to make sure that the list reflected some diversity in terms of demographics, you know, the representation of different kinds of schools, different fields, and ideally, scholars of color." At the opposite extreme, another panelist mentions that her panel did not explicitly apply diversity criteria: "We were pretty much going through and randomly judging each application on its own merits. There was no discussion of 'Well, we have too many history or we have too many of this.' There seemed to be no reason then to discuss race if you're just going through and making a determination just based on the individual projects and not other considerations." This same panelist, however, reports that during her second year on the panel, when the discussion turned to which of the proposals ranked "2" (the "maybe" category) should receive funding, she sought to promote underrepresented topics and applicants of color. "[I supported] topics that spoke to interests that I thought were not well represented in a pool of applications we had already supported . . . [and whose authors] themselves are in underrepresented groups."

It is nearly impossible to determine whether white and nonwhite panelists are equally likely to interpret diversity questions as pertaining to race, given the considerable variation that exists within each group. Moreover, because academics in the social sciences and the humanities are, overall, progressive, the promotion of diversity may very well be so taken for granted among panelists that there seems to be no need to explicitly discuss it. (As a sociologist puts it, "The people on the committee were nice and progressive people, so in our minds there was no [need for a] straightforward discussion of that.")²⁶ Nevertheless, we find positions among whites that are absent among nonwhites. For instance, one white panelist, an anthropologist, opposes any consideration of race because doing so seems patronizing toward nonwhites and to promote privileged people of color:

In my university, we are about to make an offer to someone, a woman from India who's from a high caste and probably grew up with twelve servants and so on, but she's considered under a special minority hiring. We can hire her without any search for a position that doesn't otherwise exist. I find that totally baffling. Certainly, if there were any evidence again of bias against minorities, that would be something to root out, but I just haven't encountered that . . . In other words, if we're not using the same standard, whatever that is, I'd be worried about being patronizing—you know, "Well, I've got to lower the standard, it's a black candidate."

Very few panelists mention class diversity. They do not appear to question that middle-class students, who are generally better endowed culturally for academic success through various forms of transmitted cultural capital, will be privileged in most academic selections. One interviewee, however, notes:

[Class diversity] is a deep problem for the American university in that gradually and [despite] many different kinds of efforts, the pool of people going into the humanities is becoming less diverse, wealthier, and more established—I don't know the situation in the social sciences. When you make a selection like this, you're already selecting from what is mostly [a] bourgeois group of very privileged people who have gone to elite universities and colleges, even if they didn't come from the elite . . . There were people from Harvard and Wellesley, but there was also a kid from Berkeley who supported himself managing a Barnes and Noble. So it was very good to see that we had a real range.

Awareness of Gender Bias

Social science research has contributed important findings on gender discrimination in scholarly performance evaluations.²⁷ For in-

stance, a widely cited study of peer-reviewed evaluations of post-doctoral research applications shows that reviewers consistently gave female applicants lower average scores than male applicants, despite similar levels of productivity.²⁸ More broadly, we know that men's traits are generally viewed as more valuable than women's, and that men are generally judged as more competent.²⁹ In addition, women academics are often perceived as "less productive and/or incapable of succeeding in full-time, tenure-track positions," which results in women's performances being subject to both more scrutiny and higher standards than the performances of comparable men.³⁰ "Attribution biases" are frequent; these occur when "people tend to attribute the behavior of members of their in-group to stable causes, while they attribute the behavior of out-groups to situational causes: he's brilliant, but she just got lucky."³¹ Such biases are especially likely in situations of tokenism, for example, when there are only a few women in a department or within a rank. Social categorization and same-group ("in-group") biases that lead to attribution biases are part of normal cognition, and they occur regardless of people's conscious feelings toward other groups.³² Only continual self-evaluation, time, and systems of accountability can redirect these cognitive tendencies.

These findings inform the scholarship of some of the panelists, several of whom are well versed in the literature on gender inequality in academia. For instance, a political scientist explains that men may be more likely to dismiss the work of women colleagues as "not interesting," and that such appraisals "would obviously be a case of kind of bias . . . it would be rare that you'll find that the people who are different from you are doing things that you rate more highly." Also aware of the literature on bias, a historian, when asked how he deals with questions of diversity as he evaluates proposals, answers: "I [don't] foreground them, but I try to take them into serious consideration . . . After I've gone through a batch of proposals I look for a pattern. Are the ones that I'm scoring higher distinguished by gen-

der, by discipline, [by being] at research universities, and so forth?” This panelist also recalls the panel as a whole being sensitive to bias. He provided the example of a time when “someone remarked, ‘Hey, two of the last three were not at major universities.’ And suddenly somebody attended to that matter, and we said, ‘Yes, that is true.’ We wanted to make sure we were not blindly ignoring those kinds of things.”

Others focus on some of the more subtle ways that gender influences evaluation. For instance, one sociologist, citing the work of Pierre Bourdieu and Jean-Claude Passeron on “strategies of relegation” (or self-tracking) among working-class students, suggests that women may be less likely to win fellowships because they deliberately choose more traditional topics and “safer” professional strategies.³³ Another woman, an anthropologist serving on the Society of Fellows panel, notes that men interview much better than women; they are more at ease. “[There is the] male interview style, [which is more] persuasive, and the certain female interview style, not quite as pushy. It’s not necessarily apologetic, but just not as strong. They seem not good and that’s something we have to watch out for.” Alternatively, she notes that women often lose points because they are perceived as too aggressive, in line with findings that ambitious women are penalized if they claim rewards for their achievements.³⁴ Indeed, studies indicate that when men are assertive, their behavior is perceived as evidence of great talent, but when women exhibit the same behavior, they are seen as being too aggressive. Similarly, men and women who engage in “self-promotion” are often viewed in different ways, with the men admired for their accomplishments, while the women are seen as arrogant.³⁵

Finally, indirect biases arise from the fact that women often privilege qualitative research and constructivist epistemological approaches. Elisabeth Clemens and her colleagues show that in sociology, women are proportionately more likely than men to write books, especially

books that use qualitative data.³⁶ A panel that favors quantitative work over qualitative work could thus put women at a disadvantage. In comparing the epistemological styles valued by panelists, my colleagues and I found that women were more likely to use a constructivist style than men.³⁷ A panel that values more a positivist epistemological style would thus also put women at a slight disadvantage. In these cases, discrimination results not from direct gender bias but from adopting criteria of selection that are slanted in favor of men.³⁸ Considered together, these factors suggest a possible “cumulative advantage” that works in favor of men—a possibility heightened by the presence of additional influences, such as those discussed in Chapter 5 (for example, letters of recommendation for male applicants appear to be more detailed and make a stronger impression on panelists).³⁹ Similar factors may also increase the likelihood of tenure for men as compared to women. A comparative study of young men and women academic stars could potentially reveal contrasting patterns in the role played by mentors, the passing on of privileges, and the advantages provided by having a stay-at-home partner and other informal resources.

Institutional Affirmative Action

As its name indicates, the American Council for Learned Societies is an organization of national associations. It serves a highly diverse membership. The participating associations represent those working in public and private universities, elite and nonelite universities, research universities and liberal arts colleges, institutions with heavy or light teaching loads, and universities located in less central areas. For those serving on the ACLS’s panel, therefore, diversity concerns are salient. This umbrella organization wants its distribution of awards to reflect the diverse morphology of American higher education, including its geographical dispersion and the various categories of institutions. A representational logic is not strictly applied, but it is a

factor. In this organization, distributing awards across the associations' various constituencies is a matter not only of fairness, but also of organizational efficacy.

Other competitions also ask their panelists to take institutional diversity into consideration when making awards, as this panelist indicates:

We had the usual injunction from the program officer that we should be careful to consider underrepresented institutions as one extra plus in a proposal's favor, though not to [the extent that it would] cancel out [other negative attributes] if we thought the proposal was weak. And equally, if we saw that we were over-rewarding to any given institution, to recall that. He said the way we should think about it is, we don't want all the Michigan or Columbia people in one year; we want the best of their cohort. And that means, of course, in a way, [that] the person [who's] fifth in line at Columbia in our imaginations might [have turned] out to be first in line if they [had been] at, you know, SUNY–New Paltz.

During post-deliberation interviews, more than a third of the panelists mentioned institutional "affirmative action" as a criterion of evaluation. Much as panelists are encouraged to follow the rule of cognitive contextualism by applying the epistemological style most appropriate to the applicant's field (see Chapter 4), funding program officers urge them to apply different standards depending on the resources available at the applicant's institution and the applicant's career stage. An English scholar working in women's studies describes how she factors in institutional criteria:

I'm going to cut someone less slack if they're at Rutgers or some other institution that has a lot of women's studies, or at Maryland, but [if she's] stuck at Northern Illinois or is out in Utah where there is a lot of hostility to feminist issues . . . where it's

open hostility that may even sometimes involve violence, I think, man, this person has really worked to get as far as she has. And if what she has done is excellent and there's promise that it will continue to be, then I say, that's a good affirmative action.

Panelists practice institutional affirmative action because they believe that private, elite, and research-focused universities are privileged in the competition process. For instance, an English professor observes: "When we finally looked at our final ten awards, we were chagrined that they were almost all to people at major research universities, or at places where the teaching load was probably relatively low . . . We didn't judge ourselves, but I think we had some talk about that as the proposals went by." Similarly, a political scientist says about funded projects in her field:

It didn't please me so much that three of the four political science ones went to Berkeley. I have nothing against that. I actually think Berkeley's a great place; I went there . . . I think that Berkeley does train fabulous comparative political scientists . . . But . . . you'd like to see a number of schools succeeding.

Top institutions often put an array of resources at the disposal of applicants—including internal graduate research fellowship competitions, closer mentoring, and more extensive graduate course offerings. One panelist notes, "Occasionally you get a proposal from someone that is really off the beaten track of these research universities. Clearly, they are at a big disadvantage both in not having colleagues around to help and not having the help to talk about the proposal, just not being well-informed about the kind of research method that goes on." This same person adds:

Once a student enters a second- or third-rate program and works with someone who's totally unknown, you know, even though

they might in fact have as good qualities as anybody else, they're going to be at a major disadvantage. Partly because for graduate students, it's very hard to evaluate their training other than by these kinds of institutional means.

Demonstrating the Matthew effect, according to which capital goes to capital, being affiliated with a prestigious university can keep a proposal above the bar.⁴⁰ A sociologist describes this phenomenon while discussing a project by a scholar of China who teaches at the University of Pennsylvania:

I know that Chinese literature at Penn is very highly regarded, and she can't be a dummy doing this particular kind of work, and it was a beautiful proposal . . . This is a subject that if she had been from some tiny little hole-in-the-wall college, it's not likely, I don't think. For me, I mean. I don't know about the others because we didn't really talk about these subtleties. But I know in my case, when I see where she is, and she's a professor, which they don't give out so much, I assume that this must be a very good person.

Scholars working at elite universities have a more nuanced view of differences among institutions at the top, particularly with respect to how they prepare students for competitive fellowships. A historian of China says:

People from Harvard get no advice of any kind, whereas at Stanford they have to submit draft after draft and they get all these comments . . . It's like teaching people to the test; it's not necessarily something we want to encourage . . . in the end, I want our first emphasis to be along excellence. But we have to sort of add points for certain kinds of diversity because in the end that promotes more excellence than allowing this to devolve into the control of just a few institutions.

For an English scholar, the solution is to fund “people from other than Ivy League or Research I institutions, people from sort of smaller colleges, who might not have had access to research support and might be read as ‘under-published.’ Also people from different parts of the country, people from ethnic studies, if possible, that kind of thing.”

Panelists also sometimes suggest limiting fellowships for applicants who have already received them in the past. This is a sensitive issue, in part because track record is read as indicating excellence, and in part because it raises the issue of need. Assessing need is largely framed as illegitimate—panelists do not even mention it as a consideration. Still, tensions exist around whether it should be factored in. The legitimacy of need, like that of institutional affirmative action, turns on distributive justice, which is a different principle of allocation than that of merit.⁴¹ At the center of the debates is whether scholars who have access to many resources should get more, or whether those who have access to very little should be advantaged. One panelist, a sociologist, argues strongly against institutional affirmative action because he believes that the distribution of the cultural and social capital that come with institutional affiliation cannot easily be manipulated:

The chair of our panel seemed to be quite keen on [promoting] underrepresented institutions. I tend not to be all that sympathetic to that argument. It’s stupid to be prejudiced against, say, people who are pursuing advanced graduate work at Oklahoma State. But it may very well be that, for example, just to pick a topic out of the hat, if you want to do a study of [a] nineteenth-century French critique of bureaucracy, . . . maybe it’s not the best place to pursue that kind of work, given that there aren’t adequate faculty members, you know, infrastructures or what not. So by and large, [it’s] an unfortunate fact of life that other things being equal, someone who went to Stanford and studied with Keith Baker or

whoever would probably be better off, and it's kind of silly to try to amend that.

Self-interest influences the position that some scholars take on the question of institutional affirmative action. A panelist who teaches at UCLA believes that the funding competitions are biased against public school students:

At UCLA you see a lot of bright people, but they're coming out of miserable school systems . . . They are not going to rise to the top in a competition like SSRC . . . [neither will] somebody who goes through a program that doesn't have a rigorous sort of theoretical background. So that sort of biases it against like Big Ten type schools, the UC system as a public school system. But it puts a lot more emphasis I think on the very schools that keep getting funded—Chicago, Harvard, the Ivy League schools, as well as Berkeley.

Affirmative Action Regarding Research Topics

Two of the funding competitions privilege specific types of research: that emanating from the field of women's studies (the WWNFF competition); and comparative work (the SSRC's International Dissertation Field Research competition). These competitions instruct panelists to consider potential contributions to these specific areas when evaluating proposals. But beyond these explicit and organizationally specific foci, some panelists favor topics of scholarship that they particularly value, and which they believe are neglected. This is what I call "substantive affirmative action." A political scientist who promotes it in the name of originality says:

Non-Western subjects, we felt an obligation to give those a kind of extra advantage . . . Opening up scholarship in relatively un-

touched areas seems to me a good thing to do. Some of the applications that I remember being very beautifully crafted fell lower in the rankings, either overall or just in my view, because they were going over such familiar ground. And even if the person was brilliant and had something somewhat original to say about it, I would end up feeling that this is less important work overall than scholarship in some area that Western scholars just don't have any exposure to.

Feminist scholarship and “non-Western topics” frequently are portrayed as having been historically neglected or “marginalized.” Feminist research has been circumscribed by a tradition of gender-neutral scholarship that ignores the gendered character of all aspects of social life; non-Western topics have been hampered by a Eurocentric scholarly tradition that privileges “the West” over all other areas.⁴² Both also are likely to be identified by more conservative forces as politically correct pet topics of the academic left, along with critical subaltern studies, antipositivist research, and work that addresses antiglobalization and environmentalism.

The earlier work of Everett Carl Ladd Jr. and Seymour Martin Lipset, as well as the more recent work of sociologists Neil Gross and Solon Simmons, shows how politically progressive academics are overall, especially in the social sciences and the humanities.⁴³ Thus it is hardly surprising that quality and social justice are conflated at times. Academics who see their research as contributing in very significant ways to the production of social representations are concerned with giving voice to subordinate, neglected, or marginal groups. This type of social contribution has become particularly valued since the 1980s, with the growing influence of “history from below” in cultural history; of the Birmingham School (with its focus on resistance) in English, cultural studies, sociology, and anthropology; and with parallel developments in political theory (where the

influence of critical theory remains pronounced). Of course, the development of women's studies has also had an important, independent influence as an extraordinarily dynamic interdisciplinary and disciplinary field.⁴⁴

Panelists offer a wide range of reasons for privileging scholarship emanating from women's studies or from feminist perspectives. Some appeal to homophilic preferences—where excellence is what looks most like one's own work (see Chapter 4)—but the “social usefulness of knowledge” is mentioned as well. An English professor well-known for her feminist scholarship explains:

I certainly followed my own scholarly enthusiasm; I gave high marks to “feminist” projects or projects focusing on gender . . . Gender is a very important way in which the world and cultures are organized. Even though gender scholarship has been in the academy for twenty or thirty years, I still think that it's insufficiently integrated into many scholars' understanding of the world. So I'm very happy when I see projects that incorporate gender as part of their analytic equipment.

Feminist scholarship also is sometimes promoted on the grounds that in some quarters this type of work is the target of ridicule and discrimination. One anthropologist notes, “I've served on a lot of committees now with political scientists in my own institution, and in a couple of cases cross-institutionally, and [they were] very hostile to feminist work and women's work.” An English scholar who noted little opposition to gender proposals on her panel reasons that other panelists may have felt “guilty” or been “embarrassed to admit” that they had little interest in feminist work. She contrasts this with the situation in her department, where “people make no bones about disparaging feminist scholarship. They do that very freely.”

Precisely because some panelists explicitly privilege feminist

scholarship, proposals that receive such support can be construed as substandard by unsympathetic panelists. A political scientist describes his reaction to a women's studies proposal:

This proposal that I thought was really badly done might have gone through because they were giving this woman a break. It was related to a women's studies question, her thesis. She was a woman. She was coming from a real second-tier institution. But it was a project in an area of women's studies that clearly needed more research and everything. So . . .

Feminist research is valued in part because it serves practical purposes and is meant to have a transformative social role. This standard of evaluation, however, is rejected by those panelists who value the production of knowledge as an end in itself (typically, the same panelists who espouse comprehensive or positivist epistemological styles). These opposing understandings of the purpose of research create tension. An anthropologist who directed a program in women's studies for several years notes that "women's studies people" frequently are in "a defensive battle [where] they are having to say that 'feminist' doesn't mean that academic excellence is lowered." Despite the field's increased legitimacy, "Some people are still going to bridle at the preface 'feminist' because they're going to think, 'Well, if it's related to a cause, then it can't be necessarily trustworthy.'"

The tension is not only over the aim of knowledge, but also over conceptions of objectivity and of "positionality" in the production of high-quality research. Because positivism as an epistemological style requires bracketing the relationship between the researcher and her topic, it is incompatible with developments in feminist research, whereas standpoint theory emphasizes that one's relationship with the object of study defines the lens through which the research is

conducted—a position that gives greater latitude to feminist-oriented scholarship.⁴⁵

A different logic is applied to substantive affirmative action directed toward non-Western subjects. While preferences for certain topics and perspectives in these areas could be seen as idiosyncratic, panelists legitimize them on substantive grounds (for example, by referring to breadth, originality, or scholarly significance), and do so using the language of expertise. A historian of China, for instance, emphasizes intellectual breadth when she defines diversity in opposition to Eurocentrism: “I would really welcome people who knew there was something besides the Euro-American, Western tradition and could work on it . . . I feel it’s my job to make those points, and I don’t feel that they’re necessarily very strongly influential. It’s more like a little tweak or a nag.”

She adds to the formal criteria used by the funding program a criterion of her own:

Awareness of the [intellectual] world beyond their focus . . . It’s not just international. Many people are extremely either . . . usually Eurocentric . . . or Americano-centric . . . It’s very common in the academy, but I like to point it out when I find it and I consider it a sign of narrowness . . . [I dislike] the pomposity of people who make sweeping [statements] always . . . based on Europe. As a person who’s been in the China field for thirty or forty years, it’s very annoying. It just shows their ignorance.

Another panelist, a sociologist, admits that for him, “There are absolutely some areas which are pet areas.” He favors proposals that address these topics and geographic areas not for personal reasons, but because they make accessible materials that are otherwise “hard to find.”

At the same time, some panelists refuse to engage in substantive

affirmative action because doing so seems ill-advised, like favoring proposals that emanate from one's own field. One respondent firmly rejects factoring this diversification of topics into his own thinking about what to fund:

There's no way I will be able to figure that into my reading . . . I don't have information [to make such judgments]. Even if I have the information, would I say, "OK, there are already ten people who study South Korea and this proposal is well written, but there are already ten people, and therefore I will grade it low?" [Doing that] just doesn't make sense to me.

This scholar prefers to grade on quality only, but he admits that later in the deliberative process, other factors are taken into consideration: "Then we shuffle them and put them together . . . At that level, I'm not judging them on the basis of quality, I'm just judging them on the basis of representation, and I would feel extremely fine [about it]." Separating the "real evaluation" from the negotiated rankings is a conceptual framework that allows panelists to protect the sanctity of the process (see Chapter 4).

Similarly, as a political scientist's comments suggest, by combining evaluative rationales—those related to expertise as well as to social justice—panelists can preserve legitimacy while incorporating diversity criteria. He describes his support for a proposal in archeology this way:

[The proposal] was the only one I read in archeology, and so part of it was simply trying to widen the spectrum of people [whom] we funded. But it wasn't just simply a quota system, getting an archeologist in the group photo. He made a pretty reasonable case that when anthropologists and cultural historians have studied Islam, they tended to derive most of their understandings about

medieval Islam from the urban environment. By looking at this particular spatial location . . . in terms of the mixture of different influences, cultural influences, one could have a very different understanding about the nature of medieval Islam . . . I liked the multi-dimensionality of the project.

Partly because they are interdisciplinary disciplines that concern “diverse” populations, fields such as women’s studies, African-American studies, and ethnic studies struggle to keep from being pushed to the periphery, or to the bottom of the academic totem pole. The same is true of other interdisciplinary fields, such as cultural studies.⁴⁶ That so much uncertainty remains about how to insert considerations of diversity and interdisciplinarity into scholarly evaluation underscores the fact that older, more established disciplines continue to define the rules of the game, contributing to the fragility of these fields.

Conclusion

Interdisciplinarity and diversity are among the main challenges that American higher education faces at the beginning of the twenty-first century. While interdisciplinarity has been a permanent feature of tertiary education ever since disciplines began to compete with one another to maximize their jurisdictional claims, the challenge of diversity has become even more pronounced since the 1960s, as various groups have piggy-backed on the hard-won gains that African Americans have made toward greater inclusion.⁴⁷ While elite institutions have become more diverse, conflicting visions persist, and these reverberate in panel dynamics.

Because of the very elite character of academic research, tensions around diversity may be intrinsic to American higher education, which itself is pulled between its democratic mission, the pursuit of

knowledge, and market pressures.⁴⁸ Because so many social scientists and humanists are liberal or progressive, they are also concerned that the elite not be favored at the expense of meritocracy. As an anthropologist puts it, “Those who have famous advisers and are at [the] top three or four universities will be ranked higher than people who aren’t, even if the quality of the proposal is the same. It seems to me there’s far too much elitism and just [a] sort of favoritism.”

Perhaps there is something distinctively American in how these tensions are experienced, something that is linked to the sheer size of the higher education system, to its spatial dispersion, and to its institutional diversity and its uniquely wide-ranging sociodemographic variations. That American panelists deploy so much energy to elaborate positions with regard to diversity that are nuanced and compatible indicates how aware they are of the sheer complexity of the academic world they inhabit. Their attentiveness to the issue contrasts with the situation in most European countries, where higher education systems are smaller and more homogeneous, and thus less subject to a complicated weighing of nontraditional considerations like diversity when academic achievements are evaluated. In these countries, considerations such as spreading the riches across types of institutions do not arise to the same degree. For example, the British reform of evaluation processes imposed during the 1980s promoted a straightforward application of meritocratic standards that allowed no consideration of needs and distributive fairness, in response in part to the historically ascriptive system of distribution that favored elite institutions such as Oxford and Cambridge.⁴⁹

Despite its democratic impulse, the sheer size of the American system, along with the entrenched hierarchy of institutions that characterize it, may doom efforts to free it of ongoing elitism. A British

panelist notes how American students from better universities are privileged:

They've got all the best professors anyway. For example, people talk about, "Well, you know, so and so is our supervisor, so that would give me confidence that the work will be done even despite the doubts about it," and that's so inside-knowledge. But it's also an assumption about the role between the supervisor and the student.

Nevertheless, the claims regularly made by lower-rank universities for privileging justice-inflected alternative principles of distribution are certainly a force for social change. This is the case notably within professional associations such as the American Sociological Association, where elections to important committees make room for various subcategories of candidates, including sociologists working in four-year institutions, as well as applied sociologists. The response to a push from within the American Political Science Association for a similar approach, however, is a vivid reminder that dilemmas of democracy are handled very differently across disciplines. Segments of the APSA's top leadership resisted this suggestion, preferring to maintain the status quo, whereby members simply rubber-stamp a list of nominees chosen by members of the discipline's elite—although this list does include individuals teaching in a range of types of institutions. These two different disciplinary responses, which continue to generate much angst within segments of each discipline, clearly demonstrate how meritocracy and democracy often operate as antinomic principles within the context of American higher education. That academics are struggling so hard—or not struggling at all—to reconcile them speaks volumes about their importance as buttresses to the structure of our academic world. In addition, that

these two principles exist in tension helps us understand why so often excellence and diversity do not function as alternative criteria of evaluation, but as additive, complementary factors—despite popular perceptions and rhetorical attacks against affirmative action and other policies aimed at promoting diversity within higher education. Like excellence, diversity appears to have become a moral imperative of the system—another manifestation of what is sacred in American academia.⁵⁰